

GovCon BD Upskilling Program

Competitive Positioning

Module 3.2 | Domain D3 (22%)

DURATION

2-3 hours

FORMAT

Live Instructor-Led

GovConGiants

30-Day Foundation Program

Module 3.2: Competitive Positioning

Learning Objectives

By the end of this module, learners will be able to:

1. **Research** competitors using free public data sources (SAM.gov Contract Data, USAspending)
2. **Identify** incumbent contractors and analyze their positioning
3. **Develop** win themes and discriminators that differentiate your company
4. **Assess** competitive strengths and weaknesses objectively
5. **Document** competitive intelligence in a structured brief format

Required Reading/Viewing

Official Government Resources (Free)

1. **SAM.gov Contract Data** - Contract Award Database
 - URL: <https://sam.gov/content/contract-data>
 - Focus: Researching competitor contract awards
 - Note: Requires free SAM.gov account (replaced FPDS.gov as of Feb 2026)
2. **SAM.gov** - Entity & Opportunity Data
 - URL: <https://sam.gov>
 - Focus: Finding incumbent contracts and award details
3. **USAspending.gov** - Recipient Profiles
 - URL: <https://www.usaspending.gov>
 - Focus: Competitor spending analysis (no account required)

Action Plan Journal References

- **Identify Top Supplier's Upcoming Bid Opportunities:** pages 100-101
- **Contact Email/Call Top 10 Local Primes:** pages 102-111
- **Attend Site Visits with Local Primes:** page 112
- **Site Visit Checklist:** page 113

Lesson Content

1. Why Competitive Intelligence Matters

In GovCon, you're rarely the only company pursuing an opportunity. Understanding your competition allows you to:

- **Position your strengths** against competitor weaknesses
- **Anticipate competitor strategies** and counter them
- **Price competitively** without leaving money on the table
- **Develop compelling win themes** that resonate with evaluators
- **Make informed bid/no-bid decisions** based on realistic win probability

Key Principle

You don't need to be the best company—you need to be the best choice for this specific customer on this specific opportunity.

2. Types of Competitors

Incumbent	Current contract holder	Must prove you're better; highlight transition risk they create
Direct Competitor	Does exactly what you do	Differentiate on execution, price, or approach
Adjacent Competitor	Does similar work; could expand	Emphasize your direct experience
New Entrant	New to this market/customer	Emphasize your established relationships and past performance
Teaming Competitor	Potential partner who may also compete	Watch for conflicts; consider teaming vs. competing

3. Researching Competitors with Free Tools

SAM.gov Contract Data: The Gold Mine for Competitive Intelligence

What You Can Learn from SAM.gov Contract Data:

- Who won similar contracts
- Contract values and durations
- Contract types used (FFP, T&M, etc.)
- Agency buying patterns
- Competitor portfolio breadth

How to Research a Competitor in SAM.gov Contract Data:

1. Go to sam.gov and log in (free account required)
2. Navigate to “Contract Data” → “Contract Award Search”
3. Enter competitor name in “Vendor Name” field
4. Filter by date range, agency, or NAICS code
5. Analyze results

Key Data Points to Extract:

Contract value	Size of work they handle
Period of performance	When it expires (recompete timing)
Contract type	How they price/deliver
Contracting agency	Where they have relationships
Number of modifications	Scope growth or issues
NAICS codes	What markets they’re in

Incumbent Analysis

The incumbent has significant advantages:

- Known to the customer
- Understands the environment
- Has staff in place
- Lower transition risk

But incumbents also have vulnerabilities:

- Customer may be frustrated with performance
- Costs may have grown over contract life
- Staff may be stale; innovation lacking
- Compliance issues may exist

How to Research the Incumbent:

1. **SAM.gov Contract Data:** Find original award, modifications, value

2. **SAM.gov:** Review opportunity history, any protests
3. **Customer conversations:** Listen for dissatisfaction signals
4. **Industry intel:** Talk to subs, former employees (ethically)

4. Developing Win Themes

Win themes are the core messages that answer: “Why should we be selected?”

Characteristics of Strong Win Themes:

- **Specific:** Not generic (“we’re experienced”)
- **Relevant:** Addresses what this customer cares about
- **Provable:** Backed by evidence
- **Memorable:** Evaluator remembers it

Win Theme Formula:

Win Theme Template

Because of [our unique capability/experience], we will deliver [specific benefit] that [addresses customer’s priority], as demonstrated by [proof point].

Example Win Themes:

“We have experienced staff”	“Our team includes 5 engineers with 10+ years at VA, reducing ramp-up time by 60%”
“We deliver quality”	“Our ISO 9001-certified QMS has achieved 99.8% SLA compliance across 3 similar VA contracts”
“We’re cost-effective”	“Our commercial cloud approach reduces infrastructure costs by 40% versus legacy alternatives”

5. Identifying Discriminators

Discriminators are factors that separate you from competitors. They answer: “Why us and not them?”

Types of Discriminators:

Technical	Proprietary tool, unique methodology, patented technology
Personnel	Key staff with rare expertise, former government leaders
Past Performance	Specific similar work others can't claim
Price	Lower cost structure, innovative pricing model
Relationships	Established customer knowledge, incumbent intelligence
Certifications	Security clearances, ISO certifications, set-aside status
Location	Local presence, reduced travel costs
Risk Reduction	Transition approach, warranty, performance guarantees

Discriminator Test: Ask yourself:

1. Can competitors say the same thing? (If yes, not a discriminator)
2. Does the customer care about this? (If no, not valuable)
3. Can we prove it? (If no, don't claim it)

6. Competitive Assessment Framework

Use a structured approach to assess your competitive position:

Competitive Matrix (Feature Comparison):

Technical Approach	40%			
Past Performance	30%			
Price	20%			
Small Business Plan	10%			
Total Weighted Score	100%			

Rating Scale:

- 5 = Strong advantage
- 4 = Slight advantage
- 3 = Neutral/equal
- 2 = Slight disadvantage
- 1 = Strong disadvantage

7. Ghost and Counter Strategies

Ghosting: Indirectly highlighting competitor weaknesses without naming them.

Examples:

- “Unlike approaches that rely on legacy technology, we use modern cloud-native solutions...”
- “Our approach minimizes transition risk through our proven methodology...”
- “We provide dedicated on-site staff, ensuring immediate response...”

Counter Strategies: Anticipating competitor claims and neutralizing them.

“We’re the incumbent”	“Fresh perspective + proven transition methodology”
“We’re lowest price”	“Total cost of ownership includes quality/risk”
“We have more staff”	“Right-sized team with senior experts vs. junior staff”

8. Price-to-Win Concepts

Price-to-Win (PTW) is the estimated price needed to win, based on competitive analysis.

Factors Affecting PTW:

- Incumbent’s likely price (based on current contract value)
- Customer’s budget constraints
- Market rates for similar work
- Competitor cost structures
- Evaluation weighting (is price heavily weighted?)

Basic PTW Approach:

1. Research incumbent contract value (SAM.gov Contract Data)
2. Estimate competitor pricing using public data
3. Consider customer budget signals
4. Factor in evaluation criteria weights
5. Determine if you can be competitive

Note

Detailed PTW analysis is a specialized skill typically done by capture/pricing professionals. This module introduces the concept.

AI Accelerator: Using AI for Competitive Positioning

AI tools can help you analyze competitors, develop win themes, and create compelling discriminators.

Prompt 1: Develop Win Themes

Use When: You need to create compelling win themes for an opportunity.

Help me develop win themes for this opportunity:

Opportunity: [TITLE]

Agency: [AGENCY]

Key Requirements: [MAIN REQUIREMENTS]

Evaluation Factors: [IF KNOWN]

Our Strengths:

- [STRENGTH 1]
- [STRENGTH 2]
- [STRENGTH 3]

Customer Pain Points (if known):

- [PAIN POINT 1]
- [PAIN POINT 2]

Create 3-5 win themes using this format:

"Because of [our unique capability], we will deliver [specific benefit] that [addresses customer priority], as demonstrated by [proof point]."

Make them specific, relevant, provable, and memorable.

Prompt 2: Identify Discriminators

Use When: You need to find what makes you different from competitors.

Help me identify discriminators for competing against [COMPETITOR TYPE: incumbent/large business/other small business].

Our company:

- Capabilities: [YOUR SERVICES]
- Past performance: [RELEVANT EXPERIENCE]
- Key personnel: [NOTABLE STAFF]
- Certifications: [YOUR CERTS]
- Unique aspects: [ANYTHING DIFFERENT]

Likely competitor profile:

- [WHAT YOU KNOW ABOUT COMPETITORS]

Identify potential discriminators in these categories:

1. Technical discriminators
2. Personnel discriminators
3. Past performance discriminators
4. Price/approach discriminators
5. Risk reduction discriminators

For each, explain why it matters to the customer.

Prompt 3: Ghost the Competition

Use When: You need to indirectly highlight competitor weaknesses.

We're competing against an incumbent with these likely characteristics:

- They've held the contract for [X] years
- Known/suspected weaknesses: [WEAKNESSES]
- Their likely strengths: [STRENGTHS]

Our corresponding strengths:

- [OUR STRENGTH 1]
- [OUR STRENGTH 2]

Help me develop ghosting language that:

1. Highlights our strengths without naming the competitor
2. Indirectly addresses their weaknesses
3. Sounds positive about us, not negative about them

4. Can be used in proposal narrative

Provide 3-5 ghosting statements I can adapt.

Pro Tips for AI-Assisted Competitive Positioning

Use AI to brainstorm win themes	Use AI-generated themes word-for-word
Get AI help structuring SWOT analysis	Share competitor confidential information
Draft ghosting language with AI	Write anything negative about competitors
Analyze pricing scenarios with AI	Let AI set your actual price

Remember

Great competitive positioning comes from deep customer knowledge. AI helps structure your thinking, but winning insights come from customer conversations and research.

Applied Exercise: Build a Competitive Brief

Scenario: Your company is preparing to pursue a contract currently held by an incumbent. Your manager asks you to research the competitive landscape and prepare a brief.

Part 1: Select an Opportunity

Use one of the opportunities from your Module 2.1 Opportunity Log, OR:

- Go to SAM.gov and find an active solicitation in your NAICS code
- Identify one with a known incumbent (check SAM.gov Contract Data for prior awards)

Part 2: Research the Incumbent

1. Go to SAM.gov and log in (free account required)
2. Navigate to Contract Data → Contract Award Search
3. Search for the incumbent contractor
4. Document: Original contract value, period of performance, contract type, any modifications

Part 3: Identify Other Potential Competitors

1. Search SAM.gov Contract Data for other companies with similar contract awards
2. Check DSBS for small businesses in the same NAICS code
3. Identify 2-3 likely competitors

Part 4: Complete the Competitive Brief Template

Document your analysis using the Work Artifact template.

Time: 45-60 minutes

Work Artifact: Competitive Brief

Header

Your Name: _____

Date: _____

Opportunity Name: _____

Section 1: Opportunity Overview

Agency	
Contract Type	
Estimated Value	
Set-Aside (if any)	
Response Deadline	
Period of Performance	

Section 2: Incumbent Analysis

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Incumbent Name	
Current Contract Value	
Contract Start Date	
Contract End Date	
Contract Type	
Notable Modifications	

Incumbent**Strengths:**

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Incumbent**Weaknesses/Vulnerabilities:**

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Section 3: Competitive Matrix

Technical Capability	%			
Past Performance	%			
Price Competitiveness	%			
Key Personnel	%			
Weighted Total	100%			

(Rating: 5=Strong Advantage, 3=Neutral, 1=Strong Disadvantage)

Section 4: Win Themes (Draft)**Win****Theme****1:**

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Win **Theme** **2:**

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Section 5: Key Discriminators

1		
2		
3		

Section 6: Win Probability Assessment

Overall Position	Strong / Moderate / Weak
Recommendation	Pursue / Pursue with conditions / No-bid
Key Risks	
Actions Needed	

Knowledge Check (Self-Assessment)

Question 1 (Recall)

What is the primary source for researching competitor contract awards?

- A) LinkedIn
- B) **SAM.gov Contract Data**
- C) Company websites
- D) Trade publications

Correct Answer: B

Question 2 (Application)

You're researching an incumbent and find they've received 12 modifications to their contract over 3 years, with total value increasing 80%. What might this indicate?

- A) The incumbent is doing excellent work
- B) **Possible scope creep, cost growth, or performance issues worth investigating**
- C) Nothing significant
- D) The government is satisfied

Correct Answer: B

Question 3 (Scenario)

Your win theme is: "We're a great company with experienced staff who deliver quality work." What's wrong with this?

- A) Nothing—it's a strong theme
- B) **It's too generic; competitors can say the same thing**
- C) It's too specific
- D) It mentions staff

Correct Answer: B

Question 4 (Application)

You identify that the incumbent has a weakness: their staff turnover has been high, causing knowledge loss. How would you "ghost" this in your proposal?

- A) Write: "Unlike the incumbent who has high turnover..."
- B) **Write: "Our approach ensures continuity through retained institutional knowledge and a 95% staff retention rate..."**
- C) Directly criticize the incumbent in your executive summary
- D) Ignore it

Correct Answer: B

Question 5 (Recall)

What is a "discriminator" in competitive positioning?

- A) A factor that unfairly advantages one competitor
- B) **A factor that separates you from competitors that the customer values**
- C) The lowest price
- D) Past performance only

Correct Answer: B

Manager Discussion Prompts

1. **Current Context:** “Who are our main competitors in our target markets? What do we know about their strengths and weaknesses?”
2. **Application:** “How does our company typically research competitors? Is there competitive intelligence I could help gather?”
3. **Career Development:** “What would help me understand our competitive positioning better? Are there capture reviews I could observe?”

Completion Criteria

To complete this module:

- ☐ Read all required materials (approximately 20 minutes)
- ☐ Complete the lesson content review (30-45 minutes)
- ☐ Finish the Applied Exercise (competitor research using SAM.gov Contract Data)
- ☐ Submit a Competitive Brief with incumbent analysis and win themes
- ☐ Review the Knowledge Check questions (self-assessment)
- ☐ Participate in manager discussion (or document self-reflection)

Estimated Total Time: 2-3 hours

Additional Resources

Free Tools for Competitive Research

SAM.gov Contract Data	sam.gov/content/contract-data	Contract award history
USAspending	usaspending.gov	Recipient spending profiles
SAM.gov	sam.gov	Entity verification, opportunities
DSBS	dsbs.sba.gov	Small business competitor research

Key Terms

Incumbent: Current contract holder

Win Theme: Core message about why you should be selected

Discriminator: Factor that differentiates you from competitors

Ghost: Indirectly highlighting competitor weaknesses

Price-to-Win (PTW): Estimated price needed to win

SWOT: Strengths, Weaknesses, Opportunities, Threats analysis

Competitive Matrix: Structured comparison of competitors against evaluation factors

Action Plan Journal Activities

After completing this module, use your **Action Plan Journal** to:

1. Use **Identify Top Supplier's Upcoming Bid Opportunities** (pages 100-101) to track competitor pursuits
2. Document outreach using **Contact Email/Call Top 10 Local Primes** (pages 102-111)
3. Prepare for site visits using **Site Visit Checklist** (page 113)
4. Research competitor awards using SAM.gov Contract Data and document in your competitive files

Journal Reference

The Competitive Brief you completed should be maintained alongside your Action Plan Journal. As you research more competitors, add them to your tracking system using the templates in pages 100-113.